

Calvin Isch

Curriculum Vitae

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SUMMARY

PhD Candidate at UPenn working at the intersection of NLP, computational social science (CSS), and AI evaluation. My research examines how empirical claims get distorted in scientific literature and in LLM outputs. Recent publications quantify causal overstatement in 194k publications (forthcoming, *Nature Human Behaviour*) and identify sycophantic distortion in LLM summaries of scientific work (forthcoming, *ACL*). I combine large-scale text analysis, experimental methods, and a measurement-focused approach to build and evaluate systems that faithfully represent evidence, with a focus on roles in applied AI, data science, and empirical social science.

EDUCATION

Doctor of Philosophy , University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA	Present
Computational Social Science, Annenberg School for Communication	
Master of Arts , Statistics and Data Science, Wharton School, UPenn	2024
Master of Arts in Teaching , Relay GSE, Indianapolis, IN	2022
Completed through <i>Teach for America</i> (<i>AmeriCorps</i> funded)	
Bachelor of Sciences , Indiana University, Bloomington, IN	2020
Major: Cognitive Science Minors: Liberal Arts and Management (Honors), Mathematics	
<i>Cox Research Scholar</i> : Merit-based, full-ride scholarship	

HONORS & AWARDS

2026	Information and Democracy Research Grant (\$15,000)
2024-26	Humane Studies Fellowship, Institute for Humane Studies (\$15,000 total)
2023	Summer Institute on Bounded Rationality, Max Planck Institute
2021	Teacher of the Year Nomination
2020	Faculty-panel-selected winner of IUJUR Research Slam
2019	Inducted to Phi Beta Kappa
2019	Outstanding Achievement Award, IU Cognitive Science Program

WORK EXPERIENCE

Ph.D. Candidate , The University of Pennsylvania	August 2022 – Present
Studying how humans and AI systems jointly propagate distorted empirical claims at scale using computational methods. Collaborating with Profs. Duncan Watts, Philip Tetlock, and Cory Clark.	
- Built evaluation pipelines measuring sycophancy and propagation of overclaimed causal inferences in frontier LLM summaries of scientific research. - Designed large-scale retrieval (API) and annotation workflows using proprietary and open-source LLMs for qualitative analysis of media and scientific corpora.	

- Design and run human-subjects experiments on web portals studying wisdom-of-crowds and media effects.
- Technical tools: Python, R, SQL, AWS, Git, Hugging Face, APIs, Web scraping, statistical modeling, and data visualization.
- Authored papers in *Nature Human Behaviour*, *Proceedings of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL)*, *Proceedings of the National Academy of Science*, *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, and *Social Science and Medicine*

Lead Teacher, Indiana Math and Science Academy North August 2020 – June 2022
Responsible for the academic growth and well-being of 50-70 students annually across virtual, hybrid, and in-person formats.

- Received highest possible administrator evaluation ("Accomplished")
- Founded Mathematician Monday, bringing in speakers including a neuroscientist, LSE mathematician, and others to broaden students' exposure to quantitative careers
- Served on Response to Intervention (RTI) committee to identify and support students with learning and behavioral needs
- Mentored students through CYSP Young Scholars program; Started and led the IMSA Run Club

Research Assistant, Indiana University August 2016 - 2022
Collaborated with Prof. Peter Todd and Prof. Johan Bollen on experimental and computational studies of future-thinking and cognition; continued after graduation.

- Designed and coded lab and internet experiments in JSPsych
- Conducted honors thesis on future cognition using Twitter data and cross-population analysis with an Amish sample
- Presented research at Indiana University, Arizona State, Newcastle, and Northumbria
- First-authored papers in *Behavior Research Methods* and *IU Journal of Undergraduate Research*

PRESENTATIONS

- "Awe, agency, and the Future of Humanity";
 - Cooperative Futures Institute, ASU / San Francisco — June 2026
- "Politics and Causal Overreach in the Behavioral Sciences";
 - Behavioral Science Speakeasy, American Enterprise Institute (AEI) — May 2026
- "Media Portrayals of Mortality Risks / Using LLMs for Large-Scale Qualitative Analysis";
 - MIT, New(s) Knowledge Conference — October 2025
- "Quantifying the Prevalence of Overreaching Causal Language in the Social Sciences"
 - DARPA SCIFY — September 2025 | PoINETS, Harvard — August 2025 | IC2S2, Sweden — July 2025
- "The Political Impact of Virtue Signaling" (with Prof. Diana Mutz)
 - FIRE Faculty Conference, Boston — October 2024
- "On Collaborating with Adversaries: Lessons from Those Who Have Tried It"
 - Philosophy of Science Association, New Orleans — November 2024
- "Narrative License in the Social Sciences: An Exploration with GPT-4" (short talk)

- AIMOS Conference, QUT Brisbane — November 2023
- "Social Learning Can Mitigate the Influence of Unhelpful Anchors" (poster)
 - Summer Institute on Bounded Rationality, Max Planck Institute — June 2023

PUBLICATIONS

- Isch, C.** & Jennings, G. (Forthcoming). Narrative License and Model Sycophancy in LLM Summaries of Scientific Work. Accepted to appear in the *Proceedings of the Association for Computational Linguistics 2026*.
- Isch, C.**, Dorr, T., Fasching, N., Jennings, G., & Watts, D.J. (Forthcoming) Quantifying the prevalence and impact of overreaching causal claims in social science. Accepted to appear in *Nature Human Behaviour*.
- Isch, C.** & Centola, D. (2026). Experimental Evidence that Social Learning in Structured Information-Sharing Networks Corrects Anchoring Bias. *Journal of Social Computing*, 7(1), 3-13.
- Isch, C.**, Tetlock, P. E., & Clark, C. J. (2025). Reflections on adversarial collaboration from the adversaries: was it worth it? *Theory and Society*, 1-18.
- Isch, C.** (2025). Media Bias in Portrayals of Mortality Risks: Comparison of Newspaper Coverage to Death Rates. *Social Science & Medicine*, 117542.
- Clark, C. J., **Isch, C.**, & Shariff, A. (2024). Why do organizations take political stances? A review of reasons and risks. *Social and Personality Psychology Compass*, 18(7), e12985.
- Clark, C. J., **Isch, C.**, Connor, P., & Tetlock, P. E. (2024). Assume a can opener. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 47, e36.
- Clark, C. J., Connor, P., & **Isch, C.** (2023). Failing to replicate predicts citation declines in psychology. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 120(29), e2304862120.
- Isch, C.**, Brown, R., Todd, P. M., Aktipis, A., & Pepper, G. (2023). Objective risk exposure, perceived uncontrollable mortality risk, and health behaviors. *Journal of Public Health*, 1-11.
- Clark, C. J., **Isch, C.**, Everett, J. A. C., & Shariff, A. (2023). Even When Ideologies Align, People Distrust Politicized Institutions. <https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/sfubr>
- Isch, C.**, Ten Thij, M., Todd, P. M., & Bollen, J. (2022). Quantifying changes in societal optimism from online sentiment. *Behavior Research Methods*, 1-9.
- Heiman, S. L., Hirt, E. R., **Isch, C.**, Brinkworth, J. F., Cronk, L., Alcock, J., ... & Todd, P. M. (2022). Identities as predictors of vaccine hesitancy during the COVID-19 pandemic. *Journal of Social Issues*.
- Isch, C. G.** (2020) [Book Section] The (not so) miraculous healing power of placebos. *Critical Medical Humanities*, Leah Savion, ClassPak IUB.
- Sonmez, G., & **Isch, C.** (2020). Do Environmental Resource Distributions Affect Attentional Styles?. In *CogSci*.
- Isch, C. G.**, Nordli, S.A., & Todd, P.M. (2019) Back to the future consequences. *IU Journal of Undergraduate Research*.

LEADERSHIP AND SERVICE

TEDxIndianaUniversity, Director of Curation

2016–2019

- Selected speakers and developed talks for events with 1000+ attendees; videos amassed millions of views.
- Teach for America, 2020-2022
- Selected into the 2020 cohort (~15% acceptance rate) to serve under-resourced public schools.
- Coding Club and Robocon, 2020-2021
- Founded and led twice-weekly coding club for middle schoolers; team received Honorable Mention at Robocon.
- Board of AEONS, Indiana University 2019-2020
- Faculty-nominated, committee-selected (~8% acceptance rate) advisory board to the University President.
- Midwest Undergraduate Cognitive Science Conference, Assistant Director 2018-2020
- Managed speaker selection, funding pitches, and programming

ULTRA ENDURANCE

2026	Spartan Ultra (Cincinnati) – top 5 finish, Split 9:48;53
2025	Sub-24 Hour 100-mile Ultra-Marathon, Split 16:35;58
2024	100km Ultramarathon Champion – Split 9:23;26
2023	Top 100, Ironman Maryland – Split 9:08;19
2022	Boston Marathon Qualifier – Split 2:51;06

OTHER INTERESTS

Research Integrity Agentic AI Workflows Forecasting AI Alignment Goodreads